

AGE OF MYTHOS

# North — Chapter 1 — Rise of Legends

North · Uttara · English Edition

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# Deva Bhumi — The Child Who Survived The Mountain

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Uttarakhand is where the gods come to rest. Shiva meditates at Kedarnath. Vishnu sleeps at Badrinath. The Ganga is born from a glacier's mouth at Gaumukh. This is not metaphor — for the people of Uttarakhand, the mountains are literally divine, and climbing them is an act of prayer.

Kasturika was nine when the mountain prayed back.

The avalanche came without warning — a white wall traveling at two hundred kilometers per hour, carrying boulders, trees, and the screams of everything in its path. Her parents were ahead of her on the trail. Her siblings were behind. She was in the middle, in the one spot where the avalanche split around a rock outcrop and left a pocket of air.

She lay in darkness for sixteen hours. The temperature was minus twenty. She should have died — would have died — if the body of a musk deer, killed by the avalanche, had not fallen across her like a blanket. The deer's musk gland, crushed in death, released its scent — the most precious fragrance in the Himalayas — and the warmth of its body kept hers alive.

When rescuers found her, she was curled inside the deer's belly like a fawn in a womb. She had a tiny tattoo on her wrist that had not been there before: a musk deer, no larger than a thumbprint. The smallest tattoo in the Hulmane-The-Saga — and the most dearly paid for.

Kedar-Rakshasa's tragedy began differently but ended in the same mountains. The flood at Kedarnath in 2013 killed over five thousand pilgrims. The priest who survived — the man who would become Kedar-Rakshasa — was found clinging to the temple wall, still reciting prayers. His congregation had been swept away mid-prayer, their hands still folded, their eyes still closed.

He stopped praying that day.

His first strike was at a small roadside temple — he shattered it with his pickaxe and stood in the rubble, weeping. His second was at a larger shrine. By the fifth, he had followers — people who had lost families to floods, earthquakes, and landslides, and who had prayed to gods that did not respond.

Kasturika found him at the ruins of the sixth temple. She was fourteen, he was thirty-five. She carried a knife and a blowpipe. He carried an ice-axe that could trigger avalanches.

She did not fight him. She sat down in the rubble and told him about the night in the snow. About the musk deer that saved her. About the gods that she too had screamed at, alone in the dark, buried alive.

"The mountain did not save me because I prayed," she said. "The mountain saved me because a deer gave its warmth. The gods work through the living, not through miracles."

Kedar-Rakshasa looked at her — this child with her tiny tattoo and her enormous eyes — and for a moment, the rage faltered. But only for a moment.

"Then why," he whispered, "did no living thing save my people?"

She had no answer. The Himalayan Monals called from the ridge above, their iridescent feathers catching light that the ruins below could not.

The war continues. It is the quietest war in India — fought with whispers, with pickaxes, with a child's patience against a man's grief. And the mountains watch, neither helping nor hindering, as they have watched for sixty million years.

# Ganga Simhasana — The Son The River Claimed

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Uttar Pradesh is not a state — it is a civilization disguised as a state. Ayodhya, Mathura, Varanasi, Prayagraj — each city holds enough mythology to power an entire kingdom. And the Ganga flows through it all, carrying prayers and ashes and promises, never stopping, never clean, never impure.

Gangaputra was born in the flood of the century. His mother labored in a house surrounded by rising water, and the midwife — an old woman who had delivered three hundred children and feared nothing — swore that the Ganga itself reached through the window and touched the baby's forehead. A Sarus crane landed on the roof and called once — a sound that is said to herald kings.

He grew up with the weight of a prophecy he never asked for. Every Brahmin who saw him bowed. Every warrior who met him saluted. Every politician who encountered him either wanted to use him or destroy him. His parents fought over his soul: his mother saw a future emperor, his father saw a future monk. He became neither — he became a weapon that questions why it was forged.

Kansa-Putra emerged from beneath Mathura. Literally. During the excavation of a Kansa-era dungeon, workers found a chamber that should not have existed — a room below the lowest level, sealed with iron chains. Inside was a throne made of the same chain-iron, and on the throne was a manuscript written in prison-script: the thoughts of every prisoner who had ever been chained in Mathura's dungeons, compressed into a single text of rage, despair, and a terrible clarity about the nature of power.

The man who read it walked in as a professor of political science. He walked out as Kansa-Putra.

His first act was philosophical, not violent. He walked to the banks of the Ganga during the Kumbh Mela — where 100 million pilgrims had gathered — and spoke. He did not shout. He did not threaten. He simply asked: "If the chosen one truly protects you, why are you still poor? If the river truly blesses you, why does it carry your dead? If dharma truly governs, why do the powerful live in palaces while you bathe in sewage?"

The silence that followed was more dangerous than any war.

Gangaputra felt his tattoo burn — the barasingha's antlers glowing like hot iron. He knew the answer to every one of Kansa-Putra's questions, but the answers were complicated, and crowds do not love complicated answers. They love simple ones. And Kansa-Putra's simplest answer — the system is the enemy — was spreading like fire in dry grass.

The battle between them has not been fought with spears and chains. It has been fought with words, with demonstrations, with acts of charity and acts of sabotage. Gangaputra feeds the poor; Kansa-Putra asks why they were poor in the first place. Gangaputra protects the temples; Kansa-Putra asks who built the temples on land taken from farmers.

The Sarus cranes circle above them both, crying their mating call — a sound of absolute loyalty. But loyalty to what? To the son of the river, or to the son of the dungeon?

The Ganga flows between them and judges neither. The Ganga has seen empires rise and fall and rise again, and it carries them all — prayers, ashes, and questions — to the same sea.

## Hima Chhaya — The Ghost And The Fire

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The snow leopard is called the "ghost of the mountains" because it is seen so rarely that its existence feels like a rumor. Himavati earned the same name by the time she was twenty — a shadow that moved through the Himachali peaks leaving no footprint, no sound, and no living enemy behind.

Her father was a mountaineer — the greatest climber Himachal had ever produced. He conquered fourteen peaks above 6,000 meters before the mountain took its payment: both his feet, claimed by frostbite on his final expedition. He sits now in their village home at 3,000 meters, carving wooden deities with hands that remember the grip of ice-axes, watching the peaks he can no longer climb.

Every year, Himavati descends from whatever mission the Hulmane-The-Saga has sent her on and spends one week with her father. They do not speak of her work. They carve wood together. It is the only time the Snow Ghost is not a ghost.

Himaalaya-Rakshasa chose the worst possible time to strike — during Himavati's annual descent. His Agni-Danda pierced the Shigri Glacier, and the oldest ice in Himachal Pradesh began to weep. The meltwater became a river, then a flood, then a wall of water carrying boulders and trees and the frozen memories of ten thousand years.

The flood reached Himavati's village.

She was carving a snow leopard for her father when she heard the sound — a roar that was not thunder, not avalanche, but water moving with the weight of a glacier behind it. She grabbed her father, threw him over her shoulders, and ran. The Snow Ghost, who never runs from anything, ran.

She set her father down on high ground and turned back to face the flood. The climbing daggers in her hands were useless against water — but they were not useless against the man commanding it. She found Himaalaya-Rakshasa standing in the steam of his own making, his fire-staff turning the flood to vapor around him like a god standing in a cloud.

"I am saving them," he said, gesturing at the destruction. "You do not save people by drowning them," she replied.

"I save the planet," he corrected. "People are a detail."

She attacked in silence — the Snow Ghost has no battle cry. Her daggers found his shoulder, his thigh, but the heat radiating from his staff blistered her hands. She retreated, skin peeling, and the Western Tragopan — the rarest bird in the Himalayas — landed on a rock between them. It looked at the fire-man and the ice-woman, and it was not afraid.

Himavati understood. The tragopan survives not because it fights the mountain — but because it knows where to be when the mountain rages. She withdrew, carrying her father, and let the flood spend its fury on empty ground.

Himaalaya-Rakshasa called it a victory. Himavati calls it a strategic retreat. Her father, on the high ground, finished carving the snow leopard by touch alone. It looks exactly like his daughter — solitary, patient, and waiting for the right moment to strike.



# Kurukshetra Bhoomi — The Field That Never Forgets

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The soil of Kurukshetra has never been tested for its mineral content — the scientists are afraid of what they might find. Five thousand years ago, eighteen armies met on this field and fought for eighteen days, and the blood of millions seeped into the earth. The soil should be the most fertile in India. Instead, it grows warriors.

Kurukshetraa was born during a lightning strike so powerful it created a crater on the battlefield. Her mother, a farmer's wife who had wandered onto the field during her labor (drawn, she said, by voices), delivered the child in the crater while lightning struck three more times around them. The baby did not cry. She screamed — a battle cry so fierce that the Black Francolins, who normally only call at dawn, erupted in alarm at midnight.

The mace she carries — Bhumi-Garjana — was pulled from the earth when she was twelve. She was digging in the field for arrowheads (a hobby of Haryana children, who find Mahabharata relics the way other children find coins) when her shovel struck something that shouted. Not metal ringing — a human voice, muffled by five thousand years of soil, shouting a single word: DHARMA.

Kali-Yoddha has walked Kurukshetra for millennia, but he has been waiting for this moment — the moment a warrior is born from the same soil he was born from, carrying a weapon forged in the same blood. He does not want to fight her. He wants to convert her. Because if the hero of Kurukshetra — the living embodiment of dharma-yuddha — can be shown that dharma is a lie, then the last light in the Kali Yuga goes out.

His method is not combat. It is conversation. He walks beside her on the battlefield at dawn, when Bhishma's shadow appears, and he asks the questions that Bhishma's wisdom cannot answer:

"If dharma governed the Mahabharata, why did the righteous Pandavas cheat to win?" "If Krishna was God, why did He need to lie?" "If the war was just, why do the dead still scream?"

Kurukshetraa hears the screams. They have been her companions since birth. And she knows — with the terrible clarity of someone who carries a weapon that remembers everything — that Kali-Yoddha's questions have no clean answers.

The Battle of the Dawn Fields happens every morning. Not with weapons — with words. Kurukshetraa stands at one end of the battlefield. Kali-Yoddha stands at the other. Bhishma's shadow lies between them. And they argue about dharma while the Black Francolins call the sun up from behind the horizon.

One morning, Kurukshetraa will either answer Kali-Yoddha's questions or admit that she cannot. On that morning, the Kali Yuga will either end or deepen.

The blackbucks watch from the field's edge, as they have watched for five thousand years, waiting to see which way the wind of dharma blows.

## Panch Nada — The Man Who Could Not Lose

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Punjab has five rivers, and each one has a personality. The Jhelum rages. The Chenab philosophizes. The Ravi sings. The Beas explores. The Sutlej endures. Panchanada carries all five in his blood, and in battle, he flows between their natures — raging, thinking, singing, exploring, enduring — like a river that changes course with every heartbeat.

But even five rivers cannot fill the void in a man who feels nothing.

Durjaya Singh came to Punjab's border on a winter morning, walking through the wheat fields like a farmer heading to work. He carried five swords strapped to his body in a harness of his own design — each blade named for a river, each one sharpened to a molecular edge. A Northern Goshawk circled above him, screaming its hunting cry, but Durjaya Singh did not flinch. He had not flinched in twenty years.

"I have come to lose," he announced to the border guard. "Send me your strongest."

Panchanada arrived within the hour, riding a white horse and laughing — because Panchanada always laughs before battle, the way the Ravi always sings before a flood. He saw Durjaya Singh and stopped laughing.

He recognized the curse. The Sikh tradition speaks of warriors so devoted to battle that they forget what they fight for — and the universe, in its mercy or its cruelty, gives them exactly what they asked for. Invincibility. And the loneliness that comes with being untouchable.

The Battle of the Five Blades lasted three days. Not because they were evenly matched — Panchanada was the stronger warrior. But Durjaya Singh's curse made strength irrelevant. Every strike that should have drawn blood slid off his skin. Every blow that should have broken bone bounced away. The five swords whirled around Durjaya Singh like a tornado of steel, and Panchanada fought through them with his chakram and kirpan, dancing the warrior's dance of the Nihang.

On the third day, Panchanada stopped fighting. He sat down in the wheat field, removed his turban — an act of profound vulnerability in Sikh culture — and invited Durjaya Singh to share a meal.

Durjaya Singh stood over him, five blades raised, and felt... something. Not pain. Not love. But a faint, distant warmth, like sunlight through a window too thick to see through. The gesture of a man removing his turban before an enemy — offering trust instead of steel — cracked the curse, just slightly.

"Join me at the langar," Panchanada said. "If five rivers and five blades cannot defeat you, perhaps a meal and a prayer can."

Durjaya Singh has not accepted. But he has not left Punjab either. He sits on the border, eating the meals that the goshawks bring from the langar, waiting to feel the warmth of food in his stomach. So far, he feels nothing.

But the goshawks keep bringing meals. And Panchanada's unmarked youngest son — the boy born without the blackbuck tattoo — has been seen walking toward Durjaya Singh's camp alone, carrying a bowl of dal.

The five rivers hold their breath.

## Sharada Pitha — The Snow Library

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A six-year-old boy sits cross-legged on the floor of a houseboat. The houseboat floats on Dal Lake. The lake is mirror-still under September dawn. The boy holds a reed pen. His grandfather holds a manuscript.

"Why do you copy it twice, Nana?" the boy asks.

"Because one copy lives in the boat. The other goes to the lake-side cousin."

"Why?"

"Because a boat can burn. A house can burn. But a manuscript that lives in two places will outlive both."

The boy nods. He does not understand the word "outlive." He understands the word "two." He goes back to copying.

His name is Sharad-Pandit. He is the eighth of his line — the line that began nine centuries ago when an ancestor walked from the Sharada-Pitha temple in the high passes down to the valley with a single armful of scrolls. The line that says: copy twice, give one away, never own knowledge.

By the time he is twelve, Sharad-Pandit has copied four thousand manuscripts. The houseboat has shelves that curl with the hull. Walnut-wood. Lakhi-wood. Saffron-yellow ribbon between every page. His grandfather dies in winter — the lake freezes around the boat — and Sharad-Pandit reads the funerary verses himself, because his grandfather had copied that one too.

Avantivarman-Bhrasta is forty-one when we meet him. He is the chief librarian of the Sharada-Pitha collection — a magnificent stone hall built over the centuries on the model of the original Sharada Peeth temple. He has personally catalogued ninety-six thousand manuscripts. He sleeps in the cataloguing room. He talks to manuscripts as if they are children. He weeps when one is damaged by mice.

He is not a villain yet.

One evening in the deep winter, he reads a manuscript that has been waiting in a corner shelf for eight hundred years. It is a Kashmiri account of the founding of Sharada-Pitha itself — and it contradicts every other account he knows. The other accounts say Sharada-

Pitha was founded by a brahmin pilgrim in the 6th century. This manuscript says it was founded by a tribal woman and a Buddhist nun, together, two centuries earlier.

He reads it three times. He notes that it is in a handwriting he respects. He notes that the paper is Kashmiri pulp. He notes that the inscription seal is genuine.

He thinks: if this is true, the Sharada-Pitha I have served all my life is built on a story that is half lie.

He puts the manuscript on his desk. He picks up his oil lamp. He carries the manuscript to the brazier in the courtyard. He sets it down on the coals.

He stands and watches it burn.

The shame burns longer than the paper. To answer the shame, he goes back inside, finds the secondary account that supports the official version, and reads it aloud to himself three times. The version he kept is now the only version. He has corrected the record by removing the error.

He sleeps. The next morning he is calmer than he has been in years.

Eleven years later. Sharad-Pandit, now thirty-eight, has come to the Sharada-Pitha hall as he comes every winter, to copy from the central collection. He has been reading the shelves for thirty days. On the thirty-first day, he notices a gap.

A particular shelf — the founding-accounts shelf — should contain seven manuscripts according to the catalogue index. It contains six. He checks the catalogue. The index says seven. He checks the entry-cards. The entry-cards say seven. He counts again. He finds six.

He asks Avantivarman.

"Catalogue errors. Old manuscripts move," Avantivarman says, smiling gently. "Sometimes they were never there at all. The index can lie."

Sharad-Pandit nods. He goes back to copying. But the hangul-bond is awake in him now. The Kashmir stag of his lineage reads tracks left years before — and he can feel, in the corner of his mind, the missing manuscript's track. It was here. It was read. It is not here.

He spends the next three months mapping the gaps. There are forty-seven of them. Forty-seven manuscripts that the index says exist and that the shelves do not hold. Some are about the founding. Some are about the dynasty. Some are about Kashmir's plural traditions — Buddhist, tribal, Persianate, Sufi, Tantric.

He understands, slowly, what he is looking at. He understands what kind of person makes these specific gaps. He goes to find Avantivarman.

Awantipur. The ninth-century temple ruins of Avantivarman the original — the noble king whose name the librarian carries as a curse. Snow has been falling for two days. The broken lintels carry caps of white. Black-necked cranes wheel in the air above the ruins, calling to each other across the cold.

Sharad-Pandit comes alone. He carries the Sharada-Patra unfurled across one arm — the family scroll-shield, every Rigvedic verse on it copied by hand by Sharad-Pandit himself when he was thirteen.

Avantivarman-Bhrasta is waiting. He sits on a broken pillar with a manuscript in his lap. The brazier between his feet is already lit. He looks up at Sharad-Pandit with affection. They were friends once.

"You found the gaps," Avantivarman says.

"I found forty-seven."

"There are sixty-two. You missed fifteen."

Sharad-Pandit feels the cold in his chest. He had thought forty-seven was a lot.

"Why?" he asks.

Avantivarman picks up the manuscript in his lap. He opens it to a page near the middle. He begins to read aloud — perfect Sanskrit, perfect cadence, every word precise. He reads for ten minutes. The verse describes a Kashmir founded by three peoples, woven in dispute, alive in contradiction. It is beautiful.

Sharad-Pandit knows the manuscript. It is one of the forty-seven gaps. It existed in his grandfather's catalogue. He has been told it does not exist.

Avantivarman finishes the recitation. He closes the manuscript. He places it on the brazier coals.

"There," Avantivarman says, watching it catch. "Now no one knows that verse but me. I have not destroyed it. I have curated it. The kingdom is one paragraph cleaner."

Sharad-Pandit lifts the Sharada-Patra. The Rigvedic verse he chooses is the one that begins Yatra Vishvam Bhavatyeka Nidam — where the world becomes one nest. The scroll

hardens into a flat shield in his hand.

He charges. Avantivarman does not move. He simply lifts his own weapon — the Smriti-Lipi inkstone — and begins to write on the air with the index finger of his right hand. The writing becomes visible: Sanskrit characters in dark blue smoke, holding their shape against the wind.

The characters say: SHARAD-PANDIT NEVER CAME TO AWANTIPUR.

Sharad-Pandit's charge falters. For one terrifying second, he forgets why he came. He forgets the gap-count. He forgets the manuscript on the brazier. The Smriti-Lipi is rewriting his own memory in real-time.

Then Lal-Ded-Vaak, who has been hidden in the snow behind a fallen wall, stands up and begins to recite. She recites everything Avantivarman just burned — she had memorised it from the catalogue card and the title alone, then guessed at the rest. The guesses are imperfect. But the act of reciting protects Sharad-Pandit's memory. The blue characters shudder and fade.

The scroll-shield closes. Sharad-Pandit cannot fight a man who can write him out of his own life. Not yet. Not with what he knows.

He retreats. The black-necked cranes follow him out of the ruins, calling, calling.

A hangul stag steps out from a stand of silver birches at Dachigam. Snow on his back. Steam at his nostrils. He looks at Sharad-Pandit for nine breaths.

Then he turns and walks into the trees.

Sharad-Pandit follows. The stag's tracks are clear. They are also, somehow, three months old. The hangul-bond is awake.

The tracks lead him to a saffron field at Pampore. Past the last of the autumn harvest. A woman stands among the purple crocus stalks. She wears nothing but a length of woven verse — Lal Ded's vakhs, ancient and recent, layered into one cloth. Her feet are bare. She does not look up.

"You came," Lallehwari says.

"I am — "



"The eighth Pandit. The boy who copies. The man who reads everything before he speaks. The man who walked away from a brazier because he did not know enough yet."

Sharad-Pandit kneels.

"I have a question — "

"You have many questions. The question that matters is the one you have not asked yet. Why did the manuscript on the brazier need to be burned?"

He thinks. He says: "Because Avantivarman believed it contradicted the official story."

"No. Because Avantivarman knew you had not read it yet. You were going to read it, and then read three more, and then read seven more, and the forty-seven gaps would become seventy-eight by the time you finished studying. He is not racing your knowledge. He is racing your action."

Sharad-Pandit understands.

"What do I do?"

She finally looks at him. Her eyes are old.

"You walk before you have read enough. You speak before you are sure. You act, and you accept that you will get parts of it wrong. The book is the snow's shadow. The footprint is what matters."

A black-necked crane lands on her shoulder. She does not look surprised. She extends one arm and the crane takes wing again, west, toward the high passes — toward the original Sharada-Pitha temple, where the central scroll lies on a stone shelf, untouched for centuries.

"He is going for the central scroll," Lalleshwari says. "The founding charter of Sharada-Pitha. If he burns that, every kingdom in the north loses its right to claim a memory older than him. You have three days. You will not read it before you arrive. Read it as you carry it. Speak as you go."

Three days. Across snow. Sharad-Pandit walks. With him: Lal-Ded-Vaak (memorising as she walks), Habba-Bayith (singing as he walks, his voice reaching three valleys at once), Mehjoor-of-the-Margin (writing footnotes on the air with walnut ink), and seven hundred ordinary Kashmiris who have been gathering since the cranes began to circle the houseboat library.

Seven hundred. By the second day, three thousand. By the third day, ten thousand.

They are not warriors. They are weavers, shikara-rowers, saffron-farmers, schoolteachers, a retired chief justice, six Sufi qawwals, a Pandit family from Anantnag, a Shia mother from Baramulla, a Sikh trader from Srinagar, a Bhoti monk from Zangskar, two Tibetan refugees who walked the wrong way to find their family. They follow because Habba-Bayith is singing and because Lalleshwari said walk and because they have heard about the gaps and they understand, in the bones of every Kashmiri who has been told their own history doesn't fit, what is at stake.

Sharad-Pandit walks at the front. He does not read while he walks. He has not been allowed to read the central scroll yet. He will only read it when it is in his hands.

The original Sharada Peeth. A nine-century-old temple in a high pass, half collapsed, half preserved by the cold itself. The black-necked cranes have gathered — hundreds of them — circling the temple in the thin air. The snow is bright and the sky is glass-clear.

Avantivarman-Bhrasta is inside. Karkota-Kaaki and Naga-Lipi are with him. The central scroll is on the stone shelf. The brazier is lit.

Sharad-Pandit walks into the temple. Ten thousand Kashmiris stop at the courtyard. They have come this far. They wait.

Avantivarman picks up the central scroll.

"Eight hundred and twenty years," he says. "This scroll has waited eight hundred and twenty years for someone to read it correctly. I am that reader."

"You are a librarian," Sharad-Pandit says. "Not a reader."

"There is no difference."

"There is the difference of two."

Avantivarman does not understand. Sharad-Pandit walks forward. The Sharada-Patra is in his left hand, scroll-shield open. The brazier is between him and Avantivarman. He stops on his own side of the brazier.

He says, simply: "Read it aloud."

Avantivarman blinks.

"You want me to read it aloud? Why?"

"Because I cannot let you burn it without reading it. And I cannot read it before you burn it. So read it aloud. We will both hear it together. Then we will see what you choose."

Avantivarman is suspicious. He is also, in his deepest soul, still a librarian who loves manuscripts. The chance to read this scroll aloud — this exact scroll, this central scroll, the one he has not yet allowed himself to open — is an offer his old self cannot refuse.

He opens the scroll. He begins to read.

The scroll is the founding charter. It is, of course, a contradiction. It says Sharada-Pitha was founded by seventeen people, not three, not one — Kashmiri Shaiva, Buddhist, Tibetan, Sogdian, Persian, Tantric, tribal Kol, Brahmin scholar, Sufi mystic, Jain visitor, twin sisters who could not agree on anything. Each of the seventeen wrote a clause. The clauses contradict each other. The charter requires that they remain in contradiction — a kingdom of knowledge that disagrees with itself.

Avantivarman reads. His voice begins steady. By the third clause it shakes. By the seventh clause he is weeping. He is reading the manuscript that explains why his life's work — his curation, his correction, his coherence — was a misreading from the start. Sharada-Pitha was never meant to have one history. It was meant to have seventeen.

He stops reading on the eleventh clause. The brazier is still hot. The scroll is still in his hands.

"If I burn this — " he begins.

"Then ten thousand people outside this temple have heard it," Sharad-Pandit says. "Habba-Bayith is singing it in three valleys right now. Lal-Ded-Vaak is composing a vakh for each clause as you speak. Mehjoor is writing the footnotes on the air. The Pratima-Pothi" — he holds up the modern device strapped at his hip — "is uplinking every word to forty-seven edge-nodes across Kashmir, Ladakh, and the Himalayan Buddhist circuit. You can burn the scroll. You cannot burn what we have already become."

Avantivarman looks at the scroll. He looks at the brazier. He looks at Sharad-Pandit. He looks at his own hands — smoke-stained beyond cleaning.

He places the scroll on the stone shelf. He does not burn it.

He sits down on the temple floor.

"I do not know," he says, "how to be a librarian who is not also a corrector."

"Neither do I," Sharad-Pandit says. "I do not know how to be a reader who acts. I will fail at this for the rest of my life. So will you. Sit. Eat. We will fail together. There are ten thousand people outside who will check our drafts."

Karkota-Kaaki and Naga-Lipi look at their master. Avantivarman waves them away. They go. They will keep working for him for years to come — old habits — but the central scroll survives, and the gaps in the Sharada-Pitha library begin to be filled, one slow recitation at a time, by people who memorised what Avantivarman thought he had alone.

Sharad-Pandit walks out of the temple at dawn. The ten thousand Kashmiris are still in the courtyard. They have not slept. They have been reciting.

A single hangul stag stands at the edge of the gathering. It looks at Sharad-Pandit for nine breaths. Then it walks slowly toward him.

He kneels. The stag touches its nose to his forehead. The hangul-bond completes its first level.

The tattoo on his back finishes itself — two antler-points on each side. One for the central scroll. One for the act of reading it aloud. Above the antlers, in fine ink-line, a black-necked crane is drawn mid-flight.

He stands up. His phiran is heavy with snow. His Sharada-Patra is rolled and slung. His hands are stained with ink and grease and the smoke of someone else's brazier and his own.

The seven hundred who followed him from Pampore — who became ten thousand — start the long walk home. They are singing. They are reciting. Half of them are wrong. The other half are correcting them. The correcting is wrong too. It does not matter. The corrections will be footnoted by the next generation.

What is written in snow is written in time. And what is read aloud cannot be burned.